

Welcome to Shadowdale

A Player's Primer to the Fey Dale and the Dalelands Beyond



Old Skull rising over the village of Shadowdale, where the North Ride crosses the River Ashaba at the edge of the Living Wood.

"A quiet dale, they call it. So it is — on top."

Your Starting Place

Where you stand. You are in **Shadowdale**, the Fey Dale — a small, unwall'd village of roughly a thousand souls nestled where the **North Ride** crosses the **River Ashaba**. Overhead looms the bare white granite dome of **Old Skull**, a promontory that has watched this crossing since long before the first Dalesfolk raised their roofs here. The dale proper — farmsteads, coppice, pasture — holds perhaps ten thousand across the whole valley.

The village itself is modest: timber halls, a mill on the river, the **Old Skull Inn** at its heart, and **Ashaba House** — Lady **Addee Ulphor's** lordly hall — built into Old Skull's southern base. North of the village stands the old **Silverhand farm**, where a tired and largely unhelpful **Elminster** still smokes his pipe. Beyond the fields rises the **Living Wood** — an ancient forest thick with benevolent (and not-so-benevolent) fey, drawn here by the unusual geomagical energy along the Ashaba's banks. Just north of the Silverhand farm, within the wood, a ring of standing stones surrounds the **Druid's Grove**, sacred to the fey and to Mielikki.

What a Shadowdaler would tell a newcomer. Lady Ulphor is fair and steady. The militia is small but serious. The fey are mostly kindly, provided you mind the old courtesies — don't accept food, don't give your true name lightly, and don't cut living wood from the grove. And Old Skull... well. Best not to climb it alone after dark. There are stories.

The Dalelands & Their People

The Dalelands are not a kingdom. They are a scatter of forested farming counties — **dales** — strung along the **Cormanthor Forest** and the valley of the River Ashaba. Each dale is its own small nation. They share language, tradition, and an ancient pact with the elves of Cormanthor, codified at the **Standing Stone** by which Dalereckoning is counted, but they bow to no crown.

Their common governance is the **Dales Council**, which meets at **Ashabenford** in Mistledale. The free dales — Shadowdale, Mistledale, Deepingdale, Battledale, Archendale, Harrowdale, and embattled Daggerdale — cling to independence. The southern dales (Scardale, Featherdale, Tasseldale) have fallen to **Sembia** and its Netherese overlords; **Tarkhaldale** is lost to Netheril outright. The **Shadovar** press from the north, Sembia from the south, and old **Cormyr** watches warily from the west.

The people. Dalesfolk are mostly human, with many half-elves born of the long friendship with Cormanthor. They are plainspoken, stubborn, and proud; they hold their lands as a trust for their grandchildren, and they suspect anyone who comes in search of power by sword or spell. A typical Dalesperson wants nothing more than to farm and hunt in peace — and keeps a good bow by the door for the first sign that peace will not be granted. At the first horn, the plow is set down and the militia forms.